

The Pessimistic Premise of Human Agency - A Review of *Floating Coast*

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I. INTRODUCTION

Although nature often appears in historians' depictions as a silent object [1], it nonetheless interacts with humans within history and constrains human agency. The Bering Strait, an ecologically fragile yet energy-rich region accessible to human exploitation, became a focal point of contention between American-style capitalism and Soviet-style socialism. *Floating Coast* raises important questions regarding the balance between natural agency and human agency, revealing the intertwined trajectories of environmental change and state-building in the Bering region over more than a century.

II. GENERAL REVIEW

Floating Coast is a work of regional environmental history that focuses on an area commonly perceived as a "frontier." Yet it was precisely this region—not suitable for crop cultivation and unable to support large-scale urban development—that became a core site for both American-style capitalism and Soviet-style socialism. As a key arena for energy exchange across the Pacific, it served as a treasure house of resources that fostered human modernization. This book traces how, over more than 150 years, humanity transformed the ecological wealth of this remote territory into economic growth and national power.

In examining how the United States, the Soviet Union, and Tsarist Russia took advantage of this region, the book draws extensively on local, regional, and national historical records from these countries. Its archival foundation is solid, and its claims are verified through contemporaneous sources as well as later memoirs and retrospective writings. However, the author does not rely solely on rational analysis of historical documents. Instead, she skillfully incorporates insights gained from living in and immersing herself in the local environment—complementing empirical research with imaginative, even poetic reasoning—and brings in the histories and perspectives of Indigenous Beringian peoples, offering an alternative perspective beyond the so-called civilized world.

III. UNCONVENTIONAL METHODOLOGY WITH PROBLEMS

One of the distinctive features of this book is its non-linear narrative structure. Through five different domains—the sea, the shore, the land, the underground,

and the ocean—the author presents the complex exchanges and struggles between humans and nature in the Bering Strait region. Within each domain, the narrative revolves around a specific natural resource, using a parallel analytical framework to reveal the energy dynamics among the local Beringian people, the United States, and the Soviet (or Russian) state.

A. Decentering Anthropocentrism

This non-linear approach deconstructs the anthropocentric notion of historical progression, moves beyond the traditional chronological narrative, and implicitly reveals the cyclical rhythms of the natural world. Similarly, every chapter adopts a nature-centered perspective in which a particular resource (or product) is placed at the structural center of the narrative. For example, in the first chapter, the author writes from the perspective of whales, describing how they interact with Indigenous hunters and attempt to evade commercial whalers. Although this narrative technique introduces a degree of romanticization, it effectively transforms silent natural history into a hybrid arena in which the rhythm of nature and human society are intertwined and co-evolving.

B. False Premise: Pessimism of Human Agency

However, centering nature within the narrative results in a tone that is largely negative and pessimistic. Although from the perspective of environmental history, the author attempts to avoid a strict dichotomy between "humanistic history" and "natural science" and seeks to incorporate human agency within a nature-centered narrative to illustrate human-nature interactions, the text nonetheless reveals a pessimistic view of human agency. The book acknowledges the Soviet Union's development under the slogan "man can conquer nature," yet simultaneously emphasizes the errors and failures produced under the Cold War context. Likewise, even when describing agency-driven actions such as whaling restrictions like the IWC, the author weakens their legitimacy both subjectively and objectively or selectively ignores those who are also beneficial, such as the Eskimo Walrus Commission and the Alaska Eskimo Whaling Commission[2]. As a result, this narrative approach, to some extent, downplays human agency. In fact, we should indeed make use of our agency to "confront the realities", while working against anticipated future extinctions [3]. Furthermore, the non-linear and "anti-anthropocentric" storytelling strategy may have limited effectiveness in

public engagement or education, weakening confidence in humanity’s capacity to confront challenges through development. Developmental issues should ultimately be addressed through developmental solutions, yet although many dialectical and rational development perspectives existed during the Cold War regarding frontier exploitation, the author selectively downplays them in order to further elevate the position of nature.

In each chapter, the author attempts to engage in perspective-taking on behalf of non-human entities, such as adopting the viewpoint of a whale. However, such perspective-shifting has limited interpretive value for non-living or non-human subjects, and it can easily lead to a pessimistic emotional tone. Even without considering the human activities, the environment itself can have both optimistic and pessimistic sides, and certain species are still predicted to be safe under modern hunting [4]. A more intellectually meaningful form of perspective-taking should focus on relationships among human beings or between humans and society. This is not an endorsement of anthropocentrism, but rather a call to maintain a clear distinction between humans and nature while recognizing their unity and interdependence, as Collingwood emphasizes the need to approach history differently from the natural sciences [5]. The author’s romanticized description of a seamless relationship between Indigenous communities and the natural environment blurs the boundaries between human society and natural landscapes, potentially reinforcing stereotypes rather than offering

constructive analytical insight. Moreover, local populations are, by structural and historical circumstance, the least capable of mobilizing agency to foster developmental change.

IV. CONCLUSION

Although the book is labeled as a work of environmental history, it reads more like a multispecies ethnography with strong literary qualities, inviting readers to follow animals’ perspectives or movements and to empathize with their stories. While the author attempts to escape anthropocentrism and to portray a hybrid, co-equal assemblage of humans and natural landscapes—seeking a balance between human agency and natural rhythms—the book’s singular narrative structure and its consistently pessimistic tone ultimately lead to a reading experience that may feel monotonous or disengaging for human-centered inquiry. In doing so, it further weakens the sense of human agency and falls into a paradox frequently encountered among Western readers: enjoying the benefits of development while simultaneously playing the role of moral self-reflection. This stance risks cultivating a form of psychological pessimism that may, to some extent, hinder proactive responses to environmental and developmental challenges.

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